

PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR



FIELD DAY MEDIA RIGHTS TO BIG CRICKETING PROPERTIES ARE NOW OWNED BY THE JV

IPL
(INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE)

ICC TOURNAMENTS
(INCLUDES WORLD CUP, T20, CHAMPIONS TROPHY)

BCCI
(ALL CRICKET MATCHES PLAYED IN INDIA)

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star and then, they proceeded to decimate its value by focussing instead on the TV broadcasting rights for the IPL," says Nayar. "This merger (Reliance-Disney) has been made from a position of weakness. An asset bought by Disney for \$15 billion is now being sold for about \$3.5 billion." Nayar blames Disney's "mismanagement" of the Star India acquisition for its devaluation.

In Disney's global numbers for FY24, revenue was up 3%, but the rub lay in the sports business in India. For the fourth quarter, it was at a modest \$58 million but down 37% from \$92 million for the same period last year.

Disney has struggled with its India business since it entered the market in the early 1990s through a joint venture with the K.K. Modi Group to create Buena Vista TV and launch three channels. The JV never took off really, with business largely restricted to advertising sales

for other networks. By 2001, the partners struggled to maintain the relationship over Disney's plan to launch a 100% subsidiary. The JV finally ended, and in 2004, Disney launched two kids' channels—Toon Disney and Disney Channel.

In mid-2006, Disney acquired Hungama TV and a minority stake in UTV Software Communications from entrepreneur Ronnie Screwvala. In July 2011, Disney bought out UTV Software for \$454 million. The parent Disney acquired Rupert Murdoch's 21st Century Fox for \$71 billion in mid-2018, bagging its Indian operations (then called Star India).

NV Capital's Menon thinks Disney could exit the Indian business if "offered a compelling price". Now, with fewer players, it will be interesting to see what the players are willing to pay for the IPL rights at the